

1. Maximize Data-to-Ink Ratio: Eliminating "Chartjunk"

Tufte's core principle is to strip away any non-essential visual elements. The guidelines support this by recommending:

- **Neutral Defaults:** Use **blue (#437d9e)** as the default neutral color for all visualizations to prevent bright colors from diminishing the impact of important data 1.
- **Clean Backgrounds:** For **Singlestat** panels, background coloring should be **turned off** 2. Highlighting the background is considered "unnecessarily distracting" and draws too much attention away from the actual data 3.
- **Simplified Gauges:** Instead of standard gauges, use the **Bar Gauge** set to **Retro LCD** or **Basic** 3. This provides the same information in a format that is much easier to parse 3.

2. Strategic Use of Color (Layering and Separation)

Tufte emphasizes using color to highlight significance rather than for decoration.

- **Thresholds for Goals:** Bright colors should be reserved exclusively for **clearly defined goals** 4.
- **Green (#1eb16a):** Meets goal 5.
- **Orange (#f27d05):** Close to goal 5.
- **Red (#bd362f):** Significantly outside goal 5.
- **Accessibility:** For text-based thresholds, use a high-contrast red (**#ff3a3a**) to meet AA standards 5.

3. Micro/Macro Composition: Sparklines and Hierarchy

Tufte is famous for **sparklines**—intense, simple, word-sized graphics.

- **Singlestat Sparklines:** Use **light grey (#D5DBE0)** lines with **no fill** to show trends within Singlestat panels 2. This provides historical context without cluttering the current state value 2.
- **Dashboard Flow:** Arrange data to move from **macro summary to micro detail** 6:
- **Upper Area:** Highest aggregation (Singlestat panels) 6.
- **Middle Area:** Medium aggregation (Gauges, pie charts) 6.
- **Lower Area:** Most granular, detailed charts 2.

4. Context and Integrity

Tufte argues that visual data must be accompanied by clear explanations to prevent misinterpretation.

- **Descriptions:** Always use the **description field** to provide context 5. This generates a tooltip in the upper-left corner, helping to "reduce confusion about exactly what data you're showing" 6.
- **Efficient Layout:** Utilize the **full width of the screen** and group related visualizations into logical rows or columns to show comparisons clearly 6.